What UK Fintechs Can Learn From African Mobile Money Models

Flipping the Narrative: Applying African Innovation in Developed Markets

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Part 1: Rethinking the Flow of Innovation — Why Africa Leads in Mobile Money

When the conversation turns to financial technology, the usual trajectory of innovation flows from the West to the rest. Silicon Valley ideates, London refines, and the Global South adapts. But that narrative no longer holds in the world of mobile money. In fact, if you're trying to **build efficient, inclusive, and agile financial solutions**, it's **Africa that's leading—and the UK that could stand to learn.**

Over the last decade, countries like Kenya, Ghana, and Nigeria have not only **leapfrogged traditional banking infrastructure** but have created financial systems that are more **flexible, accessible, and community-centered** than many services available in developed economies.

Consider this: as of 2024, more than **80% of adults in Kenya** have access to mobile money services like **M-Pesa**, while a significant portion of UK adults are still **underbanked or underserved** by mainstream financial institutions. And while mobile-first fintechs are popping up across Europe, **they often replicate traditional financial models**, simply offering them through sleeker apps.

Meanwhile, Africa's approach is different. The continent's mobile money revolution was not about digitizing bank accounts—it was about **redefining what a bank is.** It began with a simple need: how to send money home to family, pay for essentials, or run a micro-business without going through the red tape of formal banking. This need birthed innovations that are **leaner, more intuitive, and more embedded in daily life** than anything most Western fintechs have built.

So why should the UK take notes from Africa?

Because **constraints breed creativity.** Africa's infrastructure limitations forced fintechs to innovate around them—leading to lightweight mobile networks, agent-based banking, and powerful USSD platforms that work even on feature phones. These solutions are low-cost, accessible, and inclusive—traits many UK financial services **aspire to but struggle to achieve**.

And more importantly, Africa's mobile money systems are **designed for real humans with real, messy lives.** They're built around **community trust**, **flexible saving**, **peer lending**, and **instant**

access. This isn't just technological innovation—**it's behavioral innovation**, rooted in the way people actually live and transact.

This reversal of innovation flow—**Global South to North**—is more than symbolic. It's the future. It’s time for UK fintechs to stop looking only to San Francisco and Berlin and start studying **Kampala, Accra, and Nairobi.**

Because in many ways, **Africa figured out the future of money before anyone else did.**

Part 2: Community-Led Design — How African Mobile Money Embeds Itself in Daily Life

To understand what UK fintechs can learn from African mobile money models, we have to look beyond technology into something deeper: **design philosophy**. African mobile money isn't just successful because of the mobile phone. It's successful because it was **designed for communities**, not individuals in isolation.

In the UK, most fintech solutions are built with an ideal user in mind—typically urban, tech-savvy, and relatively financially stable. The experience is personalized, yes, but often **individualistic**. You log into your app, check your balance, make payments, invest in stocks, or take out a loan—all as a lone actor in a digital environment. It's clean, sleek, and private.

In contrast, African mobile money solutions were born from **communal needs.**

- **Sending money to family in rural areas.**
- **Paying school fees on behalf of younger siblings.**
- **Topping up a neighbor’s airtime or contributing to a funeral fund.**
- **Running informal business collectives.**

These weren't edge cases—they were the main use cases. And so the platforms were built accordingly.

Let’s break this down:

1. USSD and Agent Networks: Technology Without the Smartphone Barrier

African mobile money thrives in places where smartphones aren't universal. Services are often accessed through **USSD codes**, which don’t require internet or apps. This allows **any mobile phone—basic or smart—to become a bank.**

In the UK, a large portion of older adults or low-income households are excluded from digital banking due to poor digital literacy or limited smartphone access. **Could USSD-style services provide a parallel channel for these underserved users?** Very likely.

Meanwhile, **agent networks**—human intermediaries who help customers deposit, withdraw, or transfer money—serve not only as transaction points but also as **educators and trust-builders**. They are the human face of fintech.

What if UK fintechs trained **local community agents** in underserved neighborhoods to offer guided access to digital services? Think beyond call centers—think local presence with digital power.

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2. Social Trust as Financial Infrastructure

Mobile money in Africa is built on **trust networks**, not just encryption or KYC. Take **rotating savings and credit associations (ROSCAs)** or **chamas**—these are informal savings groups where people pool money and take turns withdrawing.

Many African fintechs digitized these models, embedding **group saving, peer lending, and social accountability** into their platforms. This didn't just improve functionality—it made users feel **emotionally and culturally connected** to the product.

UK fintechs, focused on open banking and AI personalization, can benefit by **reintroducing the social layer**:

- What would it look like to create a fintech app that helps immigrant families **pool resources** to support members back home?
- What if communities could **rate each other** on trustworthiness and financial support—not just credit scores?
- What if small business owners could **form saving circles or lending pools**, managed transparently through fintech tools?

The social design of African mobile money makes it **stickier and more meaningful.** It's not just finance. It's **community infrastructure**.

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3. Microtransactions and Flexible Products

In African markets, income is often irregular. People might earn small amounts daily or weekly. Mobile money systems respond by enabling **microtransactions**, **low-fee transfers**, and **flexible loan terms** that mirror this unpredictability.

In the UK, many gig workers, freelancers, or benefits recipients face similar income irregularity. Traditional banks and neobanks often don't serve them well. A fintech that's truly inclusive must be **designed for volatility**—not just stability.

That could mean:

- **Micro-savings options** that round up every small transaction.
- **Pay-as-you-go insurance** or **micro-loans** that adjust to fluctuating income.
- Instant access to earned wages (already emerging in "salary advance" models).

African fintechs didn’t invent these because they were trendy—they **had to**. But in the UK, where the cost-of-living crisis has upended financial predictability, this same flexibility can be transformative.

Part 3: Unlocking Innovation Through Constraints — Lessons in Lean Product Thinking

One of the most underappreciated aspects of African mobile money innovation is that it was **forged under constraint**. It didn't arise in a landscape with robust infrastructure, high smartphone penetration, or surplus venture capital. Instead, it had to work with:

- Patchy mobile signal
- Limited electricity
- Low literacy levels
- Highly informal economies
- Regulatory grey zones

And yet, **mobile money systems like M-Pesa, MTN MoMo, Airtel Money, and EcoCash succeeded**. Not despite the constraints—but often because of them.

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1. Frugality as a Design Principle

In the UK fintech space, startups often chase elegant, scalable, venture-attractive models. But this sometimes results in over-engineered solutions that don’t solve **core user pain points**—especially among the underserved.

African mobile money products succeeded because they delivered **one or two features extremely well**:

- **Send money quickly**
- **Pay bills**
- **Buy airtime**
- **Save small amounts**
- **Get a loan**

They weren’t cluttered with features. They weren’t built for quarterly investor reports. They were built to **work in tough conditions and get the job done.**

UK fintechs can benefit from adopting this frugal mindset, especially when designing for:

- The elderly
- Migrants
- Low-income users
- Non-native English speakers

Rather than layering complexity, **what can be removed** to serve these users better? What does “minimum viable” really mean when it's **maximum impactful**?

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2. Offline-First Mindsets

While the UK is largely online, **digital exclusion** is real:

- ~7 million adults in the UK are digitally excluded or under-connected.
- A good portion of these are vulnerable populations: elderly, disabled, migrants, or low-income individuals.

African fintechs dealt with this from day one, making their products:

- **Work offline (via USSD)**
- **Tolerant of network drop-offs**
- **Relying on human intermediaries (agents) when needed**

A “digital-first” mindset is great—but **digital-only** can exclude those who need help the most. Designing **offline-resilient fintech products**—think printable QR codes, SMS integrations, or pop-up human kiosks in council estates—could dramatically improve reach.

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3. Regulatory Innovation Through Collaboration

African governments, faced with explosive mobile money growth, didn’t always have perfect regulations in place. But many embraced **"sandboxing"** or **collaborative regulation**.

In Kenya, for instance:

- M-Pesa launched before there were mobile money laws.
- Regulators observed its impact, then created supportive regulation **after the fact**.
- The result was **regulatory flexibility** that allowed experimentation with financial inclusion at its core.

In the UK, regulatory pathways can feel fixed and intimidating for newer, grassroots fintechs. If the FCA leaned into **co-creation**, especially for community or inclusion-focused fintech startups, they could unlock new possibilities.

African models prove that **regulation doesn’t have to come first—it can come alongside**. Collaborative models that protect users while allowing innovation to evolve naturally are key.

Part 4: Human Infrastructure — The Power of Agent Networks

One of the most overlooked reasons mobile money succeeded in Africa is the **agent network model**—a vast, decentralized system of trusted individuals who act as **human ATMs**, onboarding points, customer support agents, and cash-in/cash-out hubs.

In Kenya alone, Safaricom’s M-Pesa boasts over **180,000 agents** across the country. These agents are:

- Often located in local shops or kiosks
- Embedded in the community
- Paid via commissions
- Trusted by their neighbors

They became **the face of digital finance**, bridging the gap between abstract mobile services and tangible, real-world access.

So what can UK fintechs learn from this model?

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1. Physical Touchpoints Are Not Obsolete

The UK fintech scene often prides itself on being **digital-only**—zero branches, full automation, app-based everything.

But:

- **Many people still value face-to-face support**, especially in matters of money.
- Vulnerable users—like refugees, the elderly, or newly banked customers—often **need physical reassurance**.
- High-tech systems can feel cold or inaccessible to first-timers.

There’s room for **human-first fintech** in the UK:

- Pop-up community fintech desks at libraries, community centers, mosques, or co-working spaces
- Mobile financial agents who help people onboard, verify ID, understand services
- Partnerships with existing trusted institutions (post offices, credit unions)

Instead of seeing these as overhead, UK fintechs should see them as **trust infrastructure**.

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2. Agents Are Educators and Evangelists

African mobile money agents often do more than facilitate transactions:

- They **explain how the system works**
- Help customers register and use services
- Calm fears about fraud or loss
- Even introduce new products like loans or insurance

In effect, they **teach financial and digital literacy in real time**, person to person.

Imagine a UK model where:

- Fintechs employ or train **community champions** in council estates or immigrant neighborhoods
- These champions help people learn how to manage their accounts, use budgeting tools, avoid scams
- Instead of cold digital onboarding, people feel **welcomed and supported**

Not only would this increase inclusion, but it would build **organic brand loyalty**.

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3. Job Creation Through Inclusion

African agent models didn't just deliver financial access—they also created **thousands of micro-enterprises**. Running an agent kiosk became a source of income and prestige.

In the UK, a similar model could:

- Create employment in underserved areas
- Upskill local residents in financial services
- Make fintech part of the **social fabric**, not just the digital one

Why not train and certify **"Fintech Fellows"** in every borough? Let fintech be not just a product, but a movement people can participate in.

Part 5: Embedded Trust — Designing for Skepticism, Not Assumption

One of the less technical but *most powerful* lessons from African mobile money platforms is how they **design for distrust**.

In many African contexts, the baseline assumption is that:

- The system might fail.
- The government might interfere.
- Fraudsters are always lurking.
- People are used to working around formal structures, not through them.

Instead of assuming trust, mobile money platforms **earned it transaction by transaction**. They embedded transparency, control, and confirmation into every step. And that’s exactly what UK fintechs can borrow—especially as they serve new, digitally wary, or economically marginalized users.

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1. Confirmation Before Commitment

African mobile money systems make it almost **impossible to send money blindly**. Here’s how:

- When sending money, you must confirm the recipient’s name.
- A summary of the transaction is shown *before* you hit "Send".
- SMS confirmations are standard for every transaction.
- Reversals, though limited, are part of the flow in some countries.

UK platforms often assume:

“The user understands what they’re doing.”

But that assumption breaks down fast for:

- Older users
- Immigrant families sending remittances
- People with cognitive challenges
- Those with poor digital literacy

UK fintechs should **take a lesson in clarity**:

- Use clear transaction previews
- Include recipient name confirmation
- Design visually intuitive steps
- Always give a final “Are you sure?” step, not as friction, but **as care**

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2. Paper Trails in a Digital World

African mobile money systems are surprisingly **transaction-record friendly**. Most users, even those with basic phones, receive:

- SMS receipts with transaction ID
- A running balance
- Instant feedback about success or failure

These receipts serve many roles:

- Proof of payment
- Dispute resolution
- Psychological reassurance

UK fintechs, especially app-only startups, often under-invest in **visible transaction history**, or **de-prioritize customer documentation**. But that small design gap can become a **trust chasm**, especially for people used to cash or traditional banking.

Let's fix this by:

- Making transaction IDs easily copyable
- Offering optional PDF/email receipts
- Giving running balance notifications, especially for auto-debits
- Allowing easy tagging or notes for each transaction

These things don't just improve UX—they improve **faith in the system**.

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3. Risk is Cultural

In African fintech, risk management is often **visible and communal**. For instance:

- Agents verify users in-person.
- Daily transaction limits are clearly set and visible.
- Many apps enforce SIM card validation and require KYC at physical points.

UK fintechs often hide their risk logic behind:

- Black-box fraud detection
- Shadowy decision-making
- "Computer says no" moments

What if UK fintechs brought that **risk education** forward?

Ideas:

- Explain *why* a transaction is flagged
- Offer clear pathways to resolve a block
- Show the user how their behavior affects risk ratings
- Give people **control levers**—like daily spend caps, locked categories, or time-restricted transfers

By **sharing power**, not hoarding it, fintechs build better trust loops.

Part 6: Agent Networks — The Original Decentralized Finance (DeFi)

Before "decentralized finance" became a blockchain buzzword, mobile money in Africa had already implemented a **real-world decentralized infrastructure**—the agent network.

These agents were:

- Street-side shops
- Kiosk vendors
- SIM card sellers
- Local entrepreneurs

And they were the **backbone** of the entire system.

In Africa, millions of people **don't go to banks—they go to their agent**. Agents:

- Load cash into the system (deposits)
- Give cash out (withdrawals)
- Help resolve issues
- Onboard users, especially with low literacy

This human-centered tech deployment enabled **scale, resilience, and trust**.

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1. The Value of Human Intermediaries in Fintech

UK fintechs often chase *full digital transformation* and pride themselves on "no branches" or "zero human customer support." But there are significant downsides to this model—especially for:

- Elderly users
- Non-native English speakers
- Immigrants unfamiliar with UK finance
- Those without access to fast internet or expensive smartphones

Learning from African agent networks, UK fintechs could explore:

- Partnering with local community centers or post offices
- Creating certified “fintech helpers” or brand ambassadors in underserved areas
- Embedding fintech kiosks in local businesses
- Training existing small shopkeepers to act as support nodes

Human infrastructure is still infrastructure. And for some users, it’s **the only bridge to digital tools**.

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2. Agents as Economic Engines

In Africa, being a mobile money agent is **a job**, not just a feature. It brings:

- Commission-based earnings
- Social status
- Embeddedness in the local economy

Mobile money agents often become **community fintech champions**—trusted advisors on finance.

In the UK, this model could help:

- Tackle digital exclusion
- Create community-based employment
- Increase usage in low-trust areas
- Provide a real-world feedback loop to fintech companies

Think about this: instead of funneling millions into London billboards, what if UK fintechs invested in **real people across towns and estates** who could represent and advocate for their tools?

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3. Offline Resilience Is Real Power

When internet or power fails, African mobile money systems **keep working**. Many rely on:

- USSD codes (text-based commands)
- Low-bandwidth interfaces
- Battery-efficient protocols

Agents also become fallback points. In emergencies, people rush to agents, not apps.

UK fintechs, on the other hand, often assume:

"Everyone has a smartphone, data plan, and 24/7 connectivity."

That’s simply not true. Some UK users:

- Can’t afford regular data
- Have older phones
- Live in areas with poor signal

Taking a cue from Africa’s agent resilience, UK fintechs should consider:

- Low-data app modes
- USSD or SMS-based commands (especially for alerts, PIN resets)
- Emergency “offline-ready” features like static QR vouchers
- Building partnerships with offline organizations to bridge gaps

Resilience = inclusion.

Part 7: Innovation Born Out of Necessity — Frugality as a Fintech Superpower

In Africa, innovation isn't always born from ambition—**it’s born from constraint**. Where infrastructure is weak, budgets are tight, and access is inconsistent, fintechs have been forced to prioritize:

- **Lean design**
- **Speed of deployment**
- **Functionality over polish**
- **Reliability over perfection**

This mindset is something UK fintechs can adopt, especially in an age where **overengineered solutions** and **bloated funding rounds** often dominate the scene.

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1. Building for the Margins First

African fintechs often begin with:

- Low-income users
- People without formal education
- People without IDs
- People in remote villages

And yet their systems scale up. Not down.

What if UK fintechs **flipped their product development logic**?

Instead of starting with high-income London-based digital natives and then “trying to reach the excluded,” what if they:

- Designed with *digital exclusion* in mind first?
- Focused on those with cognitive, financial, or technical limitations?
- Treated the most vulnerable users as their primary persona?

This is **inclusive design at its sharpest**.

When you build for the margins, everyone else benefits too.

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2. Prioritizing Simplicity Over Flash

African mobile money interfaces are famously simple:

- 4–5 digits for USSD commands
- Text-based menus
- No scrolling, no infinite dashboards
- Just: send, receive, check, withdraw

In the UK, many fintech apps are now:

- Feature-loaded
- Graphically complex
- UX-obsessed

Yet some users—especially older adults or financially anxious people—just want:

- Clear account info
- Easy money movement
- Security and predictability

UK fintechs could learn from African mobile money by:

- Offering *basic modes* for core users
- Reducing cognitive overload
- Allowing interface simplification (e.g., a toggle for "essential view only")
- Making accessibility a product priority, not a checkbox

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3. Cost-Conscious Infrastructure

African mobile money scaled **without reliance on cloud-first architectures, open banking mandates, or deep VC pockets**.

Instead:

- They leveraged telco infrastructure
- Used durable hardware and hybrid hosting
- Designed for intermittent connectivity
- Created systems that worked offline or with delay tolerance

UK fintechs, especially early-stage ones or community-focused projects, could:

- Embrace *frugal engineering*
- Reconsider how much of their stack really needs to be cutting-edge
- Focus on stability over scale (at first)
- Develop tools that degrade gracefully (e.g., offline functionality, auto-recovery, light caching)

There is no shame in going back to basics—**function is a form of innovation**.

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4. Culture of Experimentation

Africa's mobile money scene has embraced a trial-and-error culture:

- Try small features with one community first
- Pilot on a neighborhood scale
- Learn fast, then expand

The pace is informal but agile.

Contrast this with the UK, where compliance, legacy tech stacks, and perfectionist expectations sometimes paralyze innovation.

Borrowing the *"fail small and adapt fast"* mindset from Africa can help UK fintechs:

- Accelerate responsible experimentation
- Involve communities in product iteration
- Reduce the risk of large-scale feature flops
- Improve time-to-market and user satisfaction

Innovation isn't about getting it perfect. It's about **getting it real**.

Part 8: Trust Without Tech — Building Confidence in the System

In Africa's mobile money journey, trust wasn't established through glossy branding or long privacy policies.

It came from something more fundamental:

- Human networks
- Word of mouth
- Consistent delivery

UK fintechs, with all their regulatory firepower, could benefit from studying how African systems created trust **without banking licenses, without glossy cards, and often without smartphones**.

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1. Agents as Trust Anchors

One of the most brilliant aspects of Africa's mobile money model was the **agent network**:

- Small kiosk operators
- Market traders
- Mom-and-pop shops
- Neighborhood barbers

These people became:

- **Human ATMs**
- **Educators**
- **Dispute resolvers**
- **Onboarding guides**

When someone had a problem, they didn't call a chatbot or email support.
They walked to *Mama Ade's kiosk* and said, "My transfer didn't go."

And she would fix it. Or escalate it.

This **hyper-local trust loop** was stronger than any customer support SLA.

Could UK fintechs revive this?

Yes—by:

- Partnering with local credit unions, community centers, or shops
- Creating **“community fintech ambassadors”**
- Offering face-to-face fintech education in libraries or care homes
- Designing trust strategies that don’t assume the user is digitally fluent

For the financially excluded in the UK—especially the elderly, migrants, or disabled—**a human face is still the most powerful trust signal**.

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2. Trust Through Consistency, Not Complexity

In African systems:

- You send ₦1000, the receiver gets ₦1000.
- You dial *737#, it always works.
- The agent is open 7am to 7pm, like clockwork.

There’s no gamification, no clever nudges, no surprises.

It’s **boring in the best way possible.**

UK fintechs, in contrast, often innovate with speed:

- Moving features fast
- Shuffling UI layouts
- Running A/B tests on financial behaviors

But for some users—especially those with low financial confidence—this creates **uncertainty and friction**.

African mobile money models teach us that:

- **Predictability is a product feature**
- **Simplicity is a trust builder**
- **Repetition, not reinvention, builds credibility**

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3. Conflict Resolution as a Core Feature

In many African fintech setups, resolving disputes is *embedded*:

- Agents escalate issues to regional supervisors
- Transactions have unique IDs usable across platforms
- Dispute timelines are clearly communicated (often via SMS)

UK fintechs can learn from this by:

- Making dispute flows more transparent
- Allowing *human fallback options* for users in distress
- Avoiding hiding support behind endless chat loops
- Empowering users to understand the complaint process

Tech trust ≠ No human contact.
Tech trust = Knowing help is **available, accountable, and understandable**.

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4. Local Language, Local Logic

African fintech tools often offer:

- USSD or app interfaces in **local languages**
- Menus built on **culturally relevant mental models**
- Visual cues for low-literacy users (e.g., icons, colors, sounds)

Trust grows when systems “speak your language”—not just linguistically, but **cognitively and socially**.

UK fintechs can apply this by:

- Offering language customization for immigrant communities
- Designing onboarding based on real-life UK financial stories (e.g., payday loans, rent stress)
- Using illustrations that reflect **real users**, not just tech-savvy millennials

Inclusion starts where understanding begins.

Part 9: The Policy Flip — What UK Regulators Can Learn Too

We’ve spent this article exploring how UK **fintechs** can learn from Africa’s mobile money model.
But there’s one more piece of the puzzle: **policy and regulation**.

Because African innovation didn’t just come from hustle and need—it often came from **policy creativity** and **regulatory experimentation**.

In fact, some of the most transformative mobile money breakthroughs happened *not despite regulation*… but because of how **flexible** or **responsive** regulators were.

So here’s what **UK regulators and policymakers** might learn from Africa too.

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1. Sandboxes Are Good — But Greenlights Are Better

The UK is known for its FCA sandbox, which allows fintechs to test new products under regulatory guidance. It’s a good idea.
But African regulators went a step further: they sometimes **let new models fly**, then observed closely.

Examples:

- **M-Pesa** launched in Kenya before mobile money had a full legal framework.
- Nigeria allowed mobile banking **via telcos**, not just banks.
- Ghana created a **tiered KYC model**, where different ID requirements applied depending on the size of the account.

These policies weren’t about laxity—they were about **access-first thinking**.

UK regulators could learn:

- To trust small pilots even without full legislation.
- To support models that serve the excluded, even if they’re outside the traditional mold.
- To let go of the assumption that **bank = safe, and non-bank = risky**.

Sometimes, the safest system is the one that **people actually use**.

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2. KYC Can Be Inclusive — Not Just Restrictive

Know Your Customer (KYC) regulations are meant to prevent fraud and money laundering. But they can also **exclude** millions.

Africa approached KYC with flexibility:

- In Ghana, tiered mobile wallets meant someone could start with **just a phone number**, then upgrade later.
- In Tanzania, **village chiefs** could vouch for identity.
- In Nigeria, SIM registration became a **de facto identity gateway** for the unbanked.

In the UK, many fintechs still rely on:

- Passport or driver’s license
- Credit files

- Address history

This blocks out:

- Migrants
- Homeless people
- Young people without documents

What if the UK adopted flexible KYC like:

- Community references
- NHS number alternatives
- Local council-issued IDs

Innovation isn't just about features.
It's about **designing compliance that includes, not excludes**.

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3. Financial Inclusion Should Be a Mandate, Not a Metric

African central banks often **explicitly name financial inclusion** as a regulatory goal.

UK regulators often focus on:

- Stability
- Competition
- Consumer protection

Those matter. But financial inclusion is often a **byproduct**, not a **target**.

What if:

- The FCA had financial inclusion **quotas** for fintech license approvals?
- The Bank of England tracked **"digitally excluded populations served"** as a metric?
- Fintechs got **incentives** to serve underserved regions or communities?

Just like Africa, the UK has large groups that are *functionally excluded*:

- The elderly
- Low-income communities
- Digitally unconfident individuals
- Migrants and asylum seekers

They don't just need a better app—they need a **policy signal that says: you matter**.

Conclusion: Learning from the Unlikely Innovators

For years, the narrative has been clear: **"The West innovates, and the Global South catches up."**

But in mobile money and digital financial inclusion, **Africa flipped the script**.

- It innovated out of necessity.
- It scaled without formal infrastructure.
- It created trust without big tech.
- It built financial ecosystems around SIM cards, not Silicon Valley.

And now, developed markets like the UK—facing cost-of-living crises, digital exclusion, and trust breakdowns in banking—are starting to face **the same challenges** that Africa tackled over a decade ago.

It's time for UK fintechs and regulators to learn, not just teach.

Because Africa didn't just catch up.

It leapt ahead.

And if we're paying attention, we can follow its lead—not just in mobile money—but in:

- Simplicity over complexity
- People over platforms
- Inclusion over polish
- Trust over tech

The future of fintech might not be a Silicon Valley product.
It might be a **chamaa in Nairobi**, a **kiosk in Accra**, or an **agent in Makurdi**.

Because innovation—real innovation—**starts where the people are**.